



Hardship support for wild catch fishers and aquaculturalists

Australia's wild catch fishers and aquaculturalists face many risks to their business, including natural disasters, impacts of drought, pests and diseases, and other market disruptions. Australian Government programs and services can help our fishing sector plan for, manage and recover from these shocks.

Support in your area

There are many people and organisations you can talk to about your options, including:

- your state and local government
- fishing industry groups
- banks and other trusted advisers, such as fisheries extension officers and accountants
- a trusted advocate, through Seafood Industry Australia's Stay Afloat program.

The Stay Afloat program provides mental health support for the seafood industry. Services are currently provided for South Australia and Queensland. Email your state coordinator at SA@stayafloat.com.au to be connected with a trusted advocate in your region.

Algal bloom response

The Government of South Australia and the Australian Government are supporting wild catch fishers and aquaculturalists experiencing the impacts of the algal bloom in South Australia.

This includes a commitment of more than \$160 million to the algal bloom response by both governments to deliver a comprehensive suite of measures to restore and protect South Australia's coastline, back coastal communities and businesses, and ensure South Australians can continue to enjoy our beaches.

The Government of South Australia has also implemented a fishing recovery program to protect and support businesses, support recreational fishing, and protect and grow fish stocks.

The Algal Bloom Summer Plan features \$21.5 million for South Australia's fishing and marine sector. This funding has supported:

- grants to fisheries and aquaculture licence holders
- an industry response and resilience program
- licence fee relief.

A [Fisheries Structural Adjustment Assessment Panel](#) has been established to undertake a comprehensive bio-economic assessment of the Marine Scalefish Fishery and other impacted commercial fisheries to examine long-term sustainability.

Learn more about the [algal bloom response](#).

Australian Government support

The Australian Government has a range of support programs that are always available for those in hardship, including Australia's wild catch fishers and aquaculturalists.

Rural Financial Counselling Service

The Rural Financial Counselling Service (RFCS) program provides free, confidential financial counselling to farmers, fishers, foresters, and small related enterprises experiencing, or at risk of, financial hardship – regardless of the cause.

Businesses involved in wild catch fishing and aquaculture are eligible for RFCS support, provided they are commercial enterprises with 19 or fewer employees.

Rural financial counsellors can assist fishers to:

- understand their financial position through developing budgets and cash flows
- develop an action plan and take steps necessary to get out of financial difficulty
- negotiate with lenders
- build financial knowledge, skills and resilience to manage potential challenges in the future
- identify and apply for other government programs and assistance that support self-sufficiency.

To find your nearest rural financial counsellor, see [Rural Financial Counselling Service](#) or call 1300 771 741.

Regional Investment Corporation loans

The Regional Investment Corporation (RIC) delivers concessional loans on behalf of the Australian Government to support eligible businesses. These loans aim to improve long-term resilience and profitability.

New Marine Recovery Loan

From 6 May 2026, the Australian Government has introduced the Marine Recovery Loan through the RIC.

The Marine Recovery Loan supports wild catch fishing and aquaculture businesses facing financial pressure due to marine slow-onset significant ecological events.

The loan is available to those wild catch fishing and aquaculture businesses affected by the marine harmful algal bloom in South Australia.

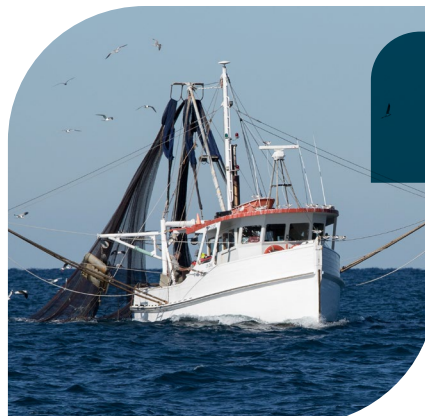
Loans include:

- amounts up to \$250,000 over 10 years
- interest-only repayments for the first 5 years
- interest rates consistent with other RIC products.

Eligible uses include refinancing existing debt, operating expenses and capital expenditure.

The loans are designed to help businesses withstand the financial impacts of the algal bloom in South Australia and assist with recovery once conditions improve.

To learn more about RIC loans, including eligibility and how to apply, see [Marine Recovery Loan](#) or call 1800 875 675.



Eligibility for other RIC loans

RIC farm business loans are for Australian businesses involved in the agricultural, horticultural, pastoral, apicultural (beekeeping) or aquacultural industries that derive their income directly from production.

Aquaculture businesses who conduct the following activities are eligible to apply for RIC loans:

- offshore longline and rack aquaculture, including offshore mollusc farming (e.g. oysters and mussels)
- offshore cage aquaculture
- onshore aquaculture.

RIC loans are for long-term viable businesses in financial need that have experienced a significant financial impact due to an event outside their control.

For each applicant, the RIC assesses eligibility based on:

- the duration of the financial impact
- existing commercial debt
- capacity to repay
- provision of security for the loan.

Farm Household Allowance

Farm Household Allowance (FHA) is an income support program assisting farmers and their partners experiencing low cash flow.

The definition of a farmer includes those engaged in aquaculture. However, wild catch fishers are not considered farmers for FHA, as their activities are classified as harvesting rather than farming.

To learn more about Australian Government income support that fits your circumstances, contact [Services Australia](#).

There are 5 components of the Farm Household Allowance:

1. Up to 4 years of fortnightly income support (in every 10-year period).
2. Ancillary allowances such as Pharmaceutical Allowance, Telephone Allowance, Rent Assistance and Remote Area Allowance and a Health Care Card.
3. A professional financial assessment of the farm business (worth up to \$1,500).
4. Funding to help develop skills, access training and pay for professional advice (up to \$10,000 per person).
5. Individual support from a dedicated case manager.

FHA is a social security payment that is uncapped and demand-driven, meaning that everyone who is eligible will receive support. Farmers, including those in aquaculture, are encouraged not to self-assess or delay applying out of concern that others may be in greater need. Call the Farmer Assistance hotline on 132 316 to discuss eligibility and ways to apply.

Learn more about [Farm Household Allowance](#).



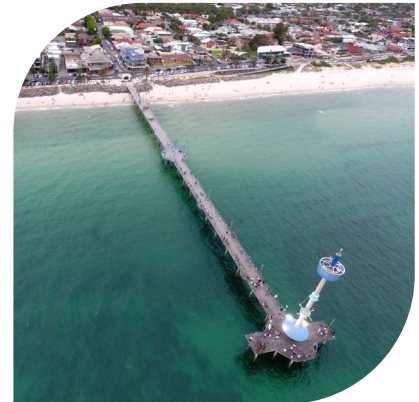
Farm Management Deposit Scheme

Primary producers, including wild catch fishers and aquaculturalists, can use previously lodged Farm Management Deposits (FMDs) to maintain business cash flow during challenging financial periods.

The FMD Scheme is designed to strengthen financial resilience by allowing producers to build cash reserves during profitable years, which can then be accessed during periods of low income.

Eligible primary producers can deposit pre-tax income into an FMD account, which is tax-deductible in the year of deposit. Withdrawals are treated as taxable income in the year they are made.

Learn more about [Farm Management Deposits](#).



Other taxation measures

The ATO offers a range of options to assist businesses in financial difficulty. For example, the ATO may be able to help by:

- adjusting pay as you go (PAYG) instalments to better suit your circumstances
- providing more time to pay, including payment plans with interest-free periods.

Primary producers, including aquaculturalists, may also be eligible to spread or defer profits resulting from insurance payments for livestock loss.

Individuals experiencing financial hardship can contact the ATO via the Emergency Support Infoline on 1800 806 218.

Learn more about [Tax support for individuals, businesses, not-for-profits and tax professionals](#).

More information

Learn more about [Drought, disaster and rural support](#).